



THE FINAL STEPS ACCORD v4.0

Phase I Stabilization Framework

NEGOTIATORS BRIEF — LATE MAY 2026

A field-ready operational guide for the final hours of mediation.
Exact citations, dual-narrative frames, and durability architecture
— designed to get this document signed before the window closes.

V4.0 UPDATE This brief supersedes all prior versions.
30 substantive changes integrated. Rolling Horizon replaces sunset.
New: Performance-Based Graduation, Joint Disposition Fund,
Media Blackout Protocol, No Military Escalation Clause.

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COMPANION TO THE FINAL STEPS ACCORD PHASE I V4.0 (65 PP.)

Contents

Section 1: Sticking Point Navigation

- 1.1 The Hormuz Compromise (JHTA + PGSA)
- 1.2 Nuclear Stockpile & Baseline Verification
- 1.3 The Lebanon Front (Dossier Isolation Firewall)

Section 2: Sanctions Relief & Performance-Based Graduation

Section 3: Dual-Narrative Verification

- 3.1 Washington's Victory Frame
- 3.2 Tehran's Victory Frame
- 3.3 The Legal Mechanisms Enabling Both

Section 4: The Rubio–Baghaei Public Rollout Protocol

Section 5: System Durability

- 5.1 Timeline Anchors (The 180-Day Roadmap)
- 5.2 The Appendix E Firewall
- 5.3 Collapse Protection Architecture
- 5.4 New v4.0 Provisions — Quick Reference

Section 6: Final Hour Checklist

Section 1: Sticking Point Navigation

The three deal-breakers that collapsed every previous negotiation — and the exact page where each is solved in v4.0.

1.1 The Hormuz Compromise — JHTA + PGSA Integration

PRIMARY CITATION: Article 4 (pp. 10–16 in v4.0 Accord) — JHTA advisory establishment, PGSA sovereignty recalibration, dual-branding transit permits, 12-month pilot phase

The Deadlock: Iran established the PGSA on 5 May 2026 as the sole Hormuz authority, requiring vessels to submit 40+ data items and pay fees up to \$2 million. The US explicitly rejected any tolling: "We don't want tolls. It's an international waterway." The IRGC considers Hormuz control a core strategic deterrent. Previous frameworks failed because they demanded one side surrender its position entirely.

The v4.0 Solution (Optical Compromise with Advisory Governance):

Element	What Iran Gets	What the US Gets
JHTA Mandate	PGSA recognized as sole coastal enforcement in Iranian territorial waters; JHTA is advisory only — non-binding recommendations	JHTA coordinates international transit corridor under UNCLOS; no Iranian tolling on international traffic; US permanent council seat
Pilot Phase	12-month pilot; permanent status requires unanimous Council renewal — Iran can block if unhappy	US can block permanent charter too; neither side locked in indefinitely
Permit System	PGSA portal processes applications; dual-branded permits	JHTA verifies against IMO/Lloyd's List/INTERPOL; fees routed through neutral MMMF in Oman
Revenue	40% of MMMF revenue to Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund	Fees are transparent multilateral maintenance payments, not unilateral tolls
v4.0 GCC Observer	No vote for GCC; Iran's veto rights unchanged	Gulf states have a voice without a vote — regional buy-in without diluting Iranian sovereignty

NEW V4.0 JHTA ADVISORY STATUS & TECHNICAL GRACE

JHTA recommendations are **non-binding**. However, if a Party disregards a unanimous Council recommendation (excluding its own vote), it must provide a written explanation within 14 days. Persistent disregard (3+ instances in 180 days) may be referred to the JIG for consultation — but **never triggers step-back**. This gives JHTA recommendations political weight without legal coercion.

IMMEDIATE TALKING POINT:

"The Strait is open to international navigation under multilateral *advisory* coordination — not Iranian unilateral control. The PGSA's role is limited to coastal enforcement within Iranian territorial waters; the transit corridor is governed by UNCLOS. The JHTA operates under a 12-month pilot — either party can prevent permanent status." (Article 4.2-A, 4.3)

1.2 Nuclear Stockpile & Baseline Verification (Article 1)

PRIMARY CITATION: Article 1 (pp. 6–9 in v4.0 Accord) — IAEA Dual-Lock Custody Exchange; 14-day consolidation; Pathway A (in-Iran) as default; Joint Disposition Fund

The Deadlock: Rubio demanded physical removal of Iran's ~400 kg HEU stockpile. Iran has communicated, as a binding sovereign position, that its enriched uranium must remain under Iranian legal title and within Iranian territory during Phase 1. This chasm collapsed every previous negotiation.

The v4.0 Solution (Two-Layer Architecture with In-Iran Default):

Phase	Timeline	Iranian Commitment	US Reciprocal
Phase 1: Baseline Verification	Days 1– 14	HEU consolidated, inventoried, placed under IAEA custody. Pathway A (in-Iran dual-lock) is the default. CBI retains sovereign legal title. Freeze on all HEU movement/enrichment from Day 1.	\$250M humanitarian tranche; OFAC general license; 5th Fleet stand-off (<i>triggered upon IAEA confirmation that consolidation has begun</i>); partial nuclear sanctions freeze
Phase 2: Nuclear Window	Days 30– 60	Select disposition pathway from six-option menu; US veto limited to Pathways D (Russia) and F (hybrid) only	Tranche 2 asset release (25%); petrochemical export licenses; Joint Disposition Fund incentives

NEW V4.0 POLITICAL WILL PRESERVATION CLAUSE

Either Party may request a **one-time 7-day extension** to the 14-day consolidation window for verified administrative, technical, or logistical constraints (IAEA inspector availability, transport delays, holidays). Such request shall not be unreasonably denied. **These delays do not constitute material breach or trigger step-back.** Removes "perfection or penalty" pressure.

NEW V4.0 IAEA CUSTODY PERSONNEL CLARIFICATION

For Pathway A (in-Iran), "IAEA custody" means the IAEA's **existing** Safeguards inspectors already in Iran perform verification. No additional IAEA personnel enter Iran unless mutually agreed. The dual-lock system is installed by **Iranian technicians** under IAEA technical supervision. **No foreign military or security personnel enter Iranian territory for custody purposes.**

NEW V4.0 **JOINT DISPOSITION FUND (\$500M)**

Capitalized by 10% from Tranche 2 + 10% from Tranche 3 releases; each Party capped at \$250M. Incentives: **\$100M** for Pathways B (Oman), C (Kazakhstan), or E (Bushehr); **\$50M** for Pathway A (in-Iran); **\$0** for Pathways D (Russia) or F with Russian involvement. Creates positive incentive for US-preferred pathways without imposing a veto. Unused funds returned proportionally.

Day 60 Default Safeguard: If no pathway agreement is reached by Day 60 of Phase 2, **Pathway A (in-Iran downblending) continues as the default** — not a breach, not a collapse. The deal survives. The ceasefire holds. Sanctions sequencing continues on the existing timeline.

IMMEDIATE TALKING POINT:

"The entire stockpile of near-weapons-grade material is placed under IAEA custody within 14 days — on Iranian soil by default, with existing IAEA inspectors only. No foreign military personnel. Breakout time extended from weeks to over a year. Iran selects the final disposition pathway freely, with a \$500 million Fund incentivizing cooperation." (Article 1.1, 1.5-A)

1.3 The Lebanon Front — Dossier Isolation Firewall

PRIMARY CITATION: Appendix E (pp. 35–42 in v4.0 Accord) — Lebanon and Levant Front Stabilization Protocol (v4.0)

The Deadlock: Iran demands an end to the war on all fronts, including Lebanon. The US/Israel want Lebanon kept separate. If Hezbollah fires rockets while the nuclear deal is being signed, hardliners on both sides demand collapse.

The v4.0 Solution (Three-Layer Firewall with Lowered Threshold):

Layer	Mechanism	Effect
Proxy Operational Pause	Hezbollah de-escalation protocol with phased operational parameters (Days 1–180)	Immediate security benefit to Israel; Iran can say the war ends on all fronts
Dossier Isolation Firewall	Legally prohibits Lebanon incidents from triggering stepback on the core US-Iran Accord	What happens in Lebanon stays in Lebanon — it cannot blow back onto Hormuz
Levant Regional Basket	Parallel diplomatic track with independent timeline; Israel has full participation	Addresses Iran's allies without requiring Iran to sit at the same table as Israel

V4.0 CHANGE **ESCALATION CEILING — REVISED DUAL-KEY**

A Hezbollah-originated attack causing **10+ civilian fatalities** in Israel triggers:

1. Automatic 72-hour consultation through Tel Aviv Channel
2. Israel retains Article 51 self-defense right

- 3. If JIG (not UNSC) determines by **majority vote** (not unanimity) that the attack was pursuant to a direct, verifiable order from the Supreme Leader, Tier 2 step-back applies proportionately
- 4. Absent such JIG determination, Core Accord continues unaffected

Old v3.2: 25 casualties + UNSC unanimity (virtually impossible). v4.0: 10 casualties + JIG majority (real but very high bar).

IMMEDIATE TALKING POINT:

"The Dossier Isolation Firewall legally prevents Lebanon incidents from triggering stepback on the core deal. Three independent levels: legal, technical, and political. The 10-casualty threshold with JIG majority vote creates a credible but very high bar — not automatic, not impossible." (Appendix E.2.2)

Section 2: Sanctions Relief & Performance-Based Graduation

PRIMARY CITATION: Article 7 (pp. 17–19 in v4.0 Accord) — Graduated Sanctions Relief with Performance-Based Graduation; Article 8 (Escrow); Article 9 (SWIFT); Appendix D (Legislative Opt-Out)

The front-loaded sanctions relief architecture is designed as a reciprocal exchange: verification milestones unlock economic benefits in phased tranches. v4.0 introduces a critical new feature: **Performance-Based Graduation** that replaces automatic expansion with earned expansion.

V4.0 MAJOR CHANGE PERFORMANCE-BASED GRADUATION REPLACES AUTOMATIC EXPANSION

The partial sanctions freeze (nuclear-related only, with terrorism/human rights sanctions remaining enforceable) **continues** until the JIG certifies Iran has achieved **all** of the following:

- 90 consecutive days of IAEA-verified compliance (no Tier 3 violations; no more than one Tier 2 violation <7 days)
- Verified HEU consolidation and custody activation
- Successful Day 7 conditional review protocol execution
- No material breach of missile/drone deployment pause

Compliance Clock Reset: Single minor Tier 2 (<7 days) resets clock to **30 days** (not zero). Second Tier 2 or any Tier 3 resets to **zero**.

US Narrative: "This isn't a sunset — it's a merit badge. Iran earns broader relief by proving compliance. If they cheat afterward, we take it back."

The Sequencing Matrix — v4.0 Protected Timeline

Trigger Event	Deadline	Relief Action	Protection Mechanism
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Accord signature; HEU freeze declared	Day 1	Humanitarian tranche (\$250M); OFAC general license; partial nuclear sanctions freeze	Irreversible upon certification
IAEA custody verified; Pathway A activated	Day 14	Tranche 1: 25% asset release; civilian aircraft parts; Joint Disposition Fund capitalization begins	Political Will Preservation Clause allows 7-day extension if needed
60-day compliance; nuclear exchange verified	Day 44	Tranche 2: 25% asset release; petrochemical export licenses; Fund fully capitalized	Tied to IAEA serial-numbered inventory
JIG certifies performance benchmarks	Day 90+	Performance-Based Graduation: sanctions freeze expands to all nuclear-related sanctions	Not automatic — must be earned. Clock reset rules protect against minor slips
Permanent JHTA operational; dual-blockade lifted	Day 120	Tranche 3: 20% asset release; SWIFT Phase 2	Telemetry-first verification; conditional Day 7 review-based protocol
12 months clean certification	Day 365	Tranche 5: 10% asset release	Material-breach hold

NEW V4.0 CONGRESSIONAL/MAJLES OPT-OUT (APPENDIX D)

Phase I does **not** require Senate ratification or Majles legislation. Phase II Commitments (permanent enrichment moratorium beyond 12 months, HEU disposition involving foreign territory, full SWIFT reconnection, permanent JHTA charter) require legislative ratification. If either legislature delays beyond 120 days without substantive cause: automatic 120-day Phase I extension; Tranche releases held in escrow; JIG assesses obstruction. If obstructive: interim disbursement to non-delaying Party (liquidated damages, not penalty). **No Party may use legislative delay to terminate Phase I.**

FLOOR GUIDANCE

Treat Performance-Based Graduation as the incentive architecture, not a trap. The 30-day reset for a single minor violation means good-faith actors are protected. The graduation threshold (90 days clean) is demanding but achievable. Frame it as "earn your way in" rather than "don't trip up."

Section 3: Dual-Narrative Verification

The exact legal mechanisms proving why both Washington and Tehran can declare victory simultaneously. If either capital asks "what did we win?" — point them here.

3.1 Washington's Victory Frame

Issue	Claim	Legal Anchor (v4.0)
Nuclear	Iran's 60% enrichment halted and placed under IAEA lock. HEU neutralized with verified physical custody within 14 days. Breakout time: weeks to over a year. US veto on Russian/hybrid pathways.	Article 1; 1.5 (pp. 6–9)
Maritime	No more unilateral Iranian tolling. Strait governed under multilateral <i>advisory</i> coordination. US permanent council seat. 12-month pilot — either party can block permanence.	Article 4.1–4.2 (pp. 10–12)
Economic	No reparations paid. Sanctions relief conditional, reversible, tied to verified compliance. Performance-Based Graduation means Iran must earn broader relief. Non-nuclear sanctions (terrorism, HR) remain enforceable.	Article 7 (pp. 17–19)
Security	Iran's missile and drone transfers to proxies frozen. No foreign military personnel on Iranian soil for custody.	Article 14 (p. 24); Article 1.1 (p. 7)
Lebanon	Core agreement addresses nuclear and navigation. Lebanon is separate file with full Israeli participation. 10-casualty threshold is credible, not automatic.	Appendix E (pp. 35–42)
V4.0 Military Firewall	Breach of the Accord is a diplomatic and economic matter, not military authorization. 14-day notice required. UNSC authorization needed.	Article 18 (pp. 32–33)
V4.0 No Sunset	Agreement has no expiration date Iran can wait out. Rolling Horizon with conditional auto-renewal. Iran must keep complying for benefits to continue.	Article 17 (pp. 30–32)

3.2 Tehran's Victory Frame

Issue	Claim	Legal Anchor (v4.0)
Nuclear	Legal title to HEU remains with Central Bank of Iran — sovereign property, not surrendered. Material stays on Iranian soil by default. NPT rights affirmed. Existing IAEA inspectors only; no foreign military.	Article 1.1 (pp. 6–7)
Maritime	PGSA recognized as sole executive coastal law enforcement in Iranian territorial waters. Iran holds permanent co-chair seat with veto. JHTA is advisory only. IRGC authority explicitly preserved. GCC has no vote.	Article 4.2-B (p. 11)
Economic	Frozen assets released through neutral escrow, not surrendered. SWIFT reconnection restores Iran's place in global economy. Performance-Based Graduation rewards compliance — punishes cheating, not negotiating.	Article 8 (p. 18); Article 9 (p. 19)

Sovereignty	No facility destroyed. Fordow conversion is optional, Phase 2 only — can remain as reduced-capacity research facility. Missile/drone programs remain sovereign and intact. 14-day timeline respects Iranian capacity.	Article 3.2 (p. 10); Article 14.2 (p. 24)
Lebanon	Framework ends war on all fronts. Through Levant Regional Basket, Iran ensures allies in Lebanon are not abandoned. 10-casualty threshold with JIG majority — not UNSC where US holds veto.	Appendix E.2.2 (pp. 37–38)
V4.0 Phase I	This is only Phase I — time-limited initial framework. No presumption for Phase II. Iran retains full negotiating position for all subsequent phases. Orderly withdrawal available with 90 days' notice.	Preamble; Article 17.4 (pp. 30–31)
V4.0 No Clawback	Funds already released from escrow prior to withdrawal notice shall not be subject to return or clawback under any circumstances. A clean break, not a trap.	Article 17.4 (p. 31)

3.3 The Legal Mechanisms Enabling Both Narratives

Both victory frames are not spin — they are legally grounded in the operative text:

Mechanism	How It Works	Citation (v4.0)
Optical Compromise	Both statements are factually accurate. JHTA coordinates international transit <i>advisorially</i> ; PGSA governs Iranian coastal waters. Neither encroaches.	Article 4.3 (p. 12)
Title/Custody Decoupling	CBI retains sovereign legal title (Iran's win). IAEA holds physical custody with US monitoring access (US win). Same clause, both claims valid.	Article 1.1 (p. 7)
Phase I Framework	Explicitly time-limited with no presumption for Phase II. Both parties retain full positions. Enables "first step" framing in both capitals.	Preamble (p. 5)
Performance Graduation	US frames as "merit badge Iran must earn." Iran frames as "rewards compliance, punishes cheating." Both descriptions are accurate.	Article 7.1 (p. 17)
No Military Escalation	US: "We control our own military decisions." Iran: "Compliance disputes don't justify airstrikes." Both correct under Article 18.	Article 18 (pp. 32–33)
Rolling Horizon	US: "No expiration date to wait out." Iran: "Either party can withdraw with notice." Both accurate.	Article 17 (pp. 30–32)

Section 4: The Rubio–Baghaei Public Rollout Protocol

Hard-coded simultaneous reading instructions for the public announcement. Negotiators must ensure neither capital deviates from the script during the conditional Day 7 execution window.

V4.0 MAJOR CHANGE DAY 7 IS CONDITIONAL REVIEW-BASED, NOT AUTOMATED

v3.2 used an **automated 60-second trigger** on the Swiss Dashboard. v4.0 replaces this with a **conditional, review-based process**:

- Day 6: Joint Review Board (Swiss facilitator, Omani mediator, IAEA representative) certifies whether both parties have met all pre-requisite milestones
- Upon certification, the Board *recommends* execution to both parties
- **Neither declaration is automated** — each party retains operational discretion over its forces
- Airspace Stand-Down Protocol activates simultaneously under the same conditional review
- Either Party may request expedited airspace coordination for legitimate operations; 2-hour response required

Why the change: Automated triggers made military commanders uncomfortable. The conditional review preserves operational discretion while maintaining synchronization.

Parallel Statement Architecture — v4.0

Element	Secretary Rubio (New Delhi)	Spokesperson Baghaei (Tehran)
Lead Emphasis	Physical custody transfer to IAEA within 14 days; in-Iran default; breakout time extended; US veto on Russian/hybrid pathways	Legal title retention by Central Bank of Iran; sovereign enrichment rights at 3.67%; existing IAEA inspectors only; 30-to-60 day disposition window
Key Phrase	"Iran's near-weapons-grade material is now under international lock and key on Iranian soil, with existing IAEA inspectors only."	"Iran's sovereign nuclear rights are preserved under IAEA safeguards, with all disposition options on the table during the negotiated window."
Framework	"This is Phase I — a time-limited stabilization framework. Iran must earn broader relief through verified compliance. No sunset, just metrics."	"This is an initial framework, not a permanent arrangement. Iran retains its full position for all subsequent phases. Either party can withdraw with notice."
What to Avoid	Never state that Iran "surrendered" material or that legal title transferred. Never characterize Pathway A as a "penalty." Never call it a "sunset clause."	Never state that Iran accepted external jurisdiction over its nuclear material. Never characterize the 30-to-60 day window as a "deadline." Never call it "permanent."

Swiss Dashboard Technical Protocol — v4.0

Parameter	Specification	Contingency
Review Process	Joint Review Board certification on Day 6; recommendations issued to both parties	If Board cannot certify, 72-hour technical consultation opens; neither declaration proceeds
Operational Discretion	Each party retains full control over its forces; declarations are recommendations, not orders	Stand-off distances (5nm) remain in effect regardless of declaration timing
Script Deviation	Pre-cleared statements only; no ad-libbing permitted	If either side deviates, floor team signals "NARRATIVE DRIFT"; corrective statement within 15 minutes

Q&A Protocol	No live Q&A during initial rollout; written statements only for first 2 hours	If pressed by media, refer to "the operative text speaks for itself"; defer to 24-hour briefing
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NEGOTIATORS' CHECKPOINT

Both statements must be reviewed and cleared by both capitals 24 hours before the rollout. The v4.0 master text is the single source of truth. Rubio's emphasis on custody and Baghaei's emphasis on title are both factually correct under Article 1.1 — this is not contradiction, it is Narrative Sovereignty by design. The conditional Day 7 review gives both military commands confidence that no automated system overrides their judgment.

Section 5: System Durability

How the timeline anchors, firewall architecture, and new v4.0 provisions protect the deal from immediate collapse — even if the first crisis hits within 72 hours.

5.1 Timeline Anchors (The 180-Day Roadmap)

PRIMARY CITATION: Part V (pp. 25–29 in v4.0 Accord); Article 11 (pp. 21–22); Article 17 (pp. 30–32)

Phase	Days	Irreversible Anchor	Verification
Foundation	1–14	HEU dual-lock custody activated (Pathway A default); IAEA inventory complete; 5th Fleet stand-off upon HEU confirmation; Political Will Preservation Clause available	IAEA custody certificate; dual-lock seals
Consolidation	15–44	Rotor removal complete; mothball protocol initiated; Black-Box telemetry at highest-risk facilities only; Joint Disposition Fund capitalized	IAEA serial-numbered inventory; encrypted data feed
Normalization	45–120	Civilian transition at 3.67% ceiling; SWIFT Phase 2 active; JHTA operational under pilot charter; Performance-Based Graduation review	OLEM confirms ceiling; SWIFT confirms
Sustainability	121–180	Fordow Phase 2 option opens; full 180-day compliance certified; Phase II readiness assessment; Phase II negotiations must commence by Day 90	IAEA + JIG joint certification

NEW V4.0 ROLLING HORIZON ARCHITECTURE (ARTICLE 17)

Replaces fixed sunset clause with **conditional auto-renewal**:

- Phase I (Days 1–180) → Phase II (Months 6–18) → Phase III (Months 18–36+)
- Each phase auto-renews upon IAEA clean compliance + JIG majority confirmation
- If conditions not met: enters **Stabilized Hold** (humanitarian + Survival Core survive)
- Orderly withdrawal: 90 days (Phase I) / 180 days (Phase II) / 365 days (Phase III)
- **No clawback** of funds already released

- Successor Framework negotiations must commence by Day 90 regardless of certification
- US Narrative:** "No expiration date Iran can wait out. The ball is always in Tehran's court."
- Iranian Narrative:** "Not a permanent surrender. Either party can withdraw with notice."

The Ceasefire Architecture — Article 11.2

The ceasefire is a self-renewing 72-hour module. If verification teams report compliance at Hour 71, the module auto-renews for another 72 hours. Peace is maintained without either side signing away long-term leverage upfront. The ceasefire clock (72-hour loops) and the implementation clock (30-day phases) are separate — neutralizing the "negotiation about negotiation" trap.

5.2 The Appendix E Firewall

PRIMARY CITATION: Appendix E.2 (pp. 36–38 in v4.0 Accord)

Level	Mechanism	Practical Effect
Legal	Exchange of Letters excludes "incidents in the Levant theater involving non-state actors" from stepback trigger definition in Article 13	A Hezbollah rocket strike is legally excluded from triggering Accord suspension
Technical	Swiss Dashboard maintains separate tracks for "Core Accord Compliance" and "Regional Security Incidents." Stepback algorithms reference only Core Compliance.	Even if a Lebanon incident is logged, it cannot trigger automated stepback
Political	Both capitals issue pre-cleared talking points confirming Lebanon is a separate file. No official may publicly link Hormuz to Lebanon without narrative violation penalties. 72-hour media blackout for attribution deliberations.	Political pressure to collapse the deal over Lebanon incidents is preemptively neutralized; leaks during attribution face Tier 1 (junior) or Tier 2 (senior official) consequences

5.3 Collapse Protection Architecture

PRIMARY CITATIONS: Article 13 (pp. 22–24); Article 18 (pp. 32–33); Part V — Framework Survival Core (p. 28); Article 17 (pp. 30–32)

Failure Mode	Response	What Survives
Tier 1: Technical dispute (<0.5% above ceiling; ≤2 rotors)	14-day engineering resolution; no rollback; confidential handling	Everything
Tier 2: Material disruption (>0.5% above; >2 rotors; >72h obstruction)	Up to 25% benefit reduction; 30-day remediation; full restore on clean certification. Proportional: 10% if <7 days.	Humanitarian tranches; ceasefire; Survival Core
Tier 3: Deliberate hostile violation (nuclear weapons activity; fissile diversion; IAEA attack)	Up to 50% reduction; 90-day remediation; full earn-back after sustained compliance. Proportional: 25% if remediated within 72h.	Humanitarian corridor; diplomatic channel; Survival Core (180 days)

Full suspension	Reconstitution Conference within 30 days (Pakistan/UN-convened)	Ceasefire hotline; humanitarian access; emergency diplomatic channel; "No Cliff" principle: Survival Core 180 days
v4.0 Military escalation attempt	Step-back is NOT authorization for military action. 14-day advance notice required. UNSC authorization required (except ongoing Article 51 attack). Exhaust all dispute resolution first.	Article 18 survives even total framework suspension for 365 days
v4.0 Media leak during attribution	72-hour mandatory blackout. Junior official: Tier 1 demerit. Senior official (minister+): JIG referral for Tier 2 step-back (5% reduction, 30 days) if deliberate and material.	Attribution process integrity protected

The Three Immutable Principles

- 1. **Telemetry-First Diplomacy:** Every commitment must be expressible as a sensor reading, data feed, or physical lock confirmation.
- 2. **Rollback, Not Snapback:** If either party breaches, the Framework does not collapse. It pauses in graduated tiers with proportionate penalties.
- 3. **Modular Architecture:** Failure in one module does not cascade. Maritime disputes cannot terminate humanitarian channels. Nuclear verification gaps do not affect Hormuz transit. Lebanon incidents cannot collapse the core agreement. Military escalation is explicitly decoupled from compliance penalties.

5.4 New v4.0 Provisions — Quick Reference

Provision	Location	Purpose	Talking Point
Political Will Preservation Clause	Article 1.1	7-day extension for verified admin delays; not a breach	"Good faith delays don't collapse the deal."
IAEA Personnel Clarification	Article 1.1	Existing inspectors only; no foreign military	"No foreign boots on Iranian soil."
Joint Disposition Fund	Article 1.5-A	\$500M incentive for cooperative pathways	"We reward cooperation, not impose vetoes."
JHTA Advisory + Pilot	Article 4.2-A	Non-binding; 12-month pilot; either party blocks permanence	"Advisory coordination, not supranational authority."
GCC Consultative Observer	Article 4.4	Gulf voice without vote	"Gulf states have a voice without a vote — regional buy-in without diluting Iranian sovereignty."
Conditional Day 7 Review	Article 6.3	Joint Review Board certifies; parties retain discretion	"Humans decide, machines inform."

Airspace Stand-Down	Article 6.3	Integrated into conditional review; 2-hour ops response	"Airspace coordination, not automatic escalation."
Performance-Based Graduation	Article 7.1	Earned relief with 30-day reset for minor slips	"Merit badge, not sunset."
Congressional/Majles Opt-Out	Appendix D	Phase I by executive action; Phase II needs ratification	"Act now, ratify later."
Proportional Penalties	Article 13.3	10% for brief Tier 2; 25% for remediated Tier 3	"Proportionate, not punitive."
Media Blackout	Article 13.5	72-hour blackout; senior leaks face Tier 2 (5% per incident; repeat offenses escalate)	"No premature attribution by press release."
Rolling Horizon	Article 17	Conditional auto-renewal replaces sunset	"No expiration date to wait out."
No Military Escalation	Article 18	Breach is diplomatic/economic, not military authorization	"Compliance disputes don't justify airstrikes."
No Clawback	Article 17.4	Released funds cannot be recalled upon withdrawal	"A clean break, not a trap."

Section 6: Final Hour Checklist

Last-minute responses for the questions that will come at you in the closing hours. Memorize these page references.

Crisis Response Quick-Reference

If They Say...	You Say...	Turn to Page
"Iran keeps the uranium on its soil — that's unacceptable."	"Physical custody is with the IAEA. CBI retains legal title only. Breakout time goes from weeks to over a year. In-Iran custody uses existing IAEA inspectors — no foreign military personnel."	6–9 (v4.0 Accord)
"The PGSA is just Iranian tolling by another name."	"PGSA only operates in Iranian territorial waters. The JHTA is advisory only — non-binding recommendations, 12-month pilot. All commercial fees are routed through the neutral MMMF in Oman. The US holds a permanent council seat with veto."	10–12
"If Hezbollah attacks, the whole deal collapses."	"The Dossier Isolation Firewall legally prevents Lebanon incidents from triggering stepback. Three independent levels: legal, technical, and political. The 10-casualty threshold with JIG majority vote is credible but not automatic. A 72-hour media blackout protects attribution integrity."	35–42

"What if we can't agree on a disposition pathway?"	"Iran selects freely from six options. The US only vetoes Russia and hybrid pathways. A \$500 million Joint Disposition Fund incentivizes cooperative choices — \$100 million for Oman, Kazakhstan, or Bushehr. If no agreement by Day 60, Pathway A (in-Iran downblending) continues as the default. Not a breach."	8–9
"This is an all-or-nothing treaty."	"The framework is strictly modular and explicitly Phase I only. Maritime coordination operates independently of friction in external theaters. Collapse in one basket does not cascade. Performance-Based Graduation means relief is earned, not given. And Article 18 explicitly states that breach is not military authorization."	28, 32– 33
"How can both sides claim victory?"	"Because both claims are factually accurate under the operative text. Every provision is designed as an optical compromise — both narratives are legally grounded. The Phase I framing means both leaders can sell this as a 'first step' without surrender."	5, 7, 12, 30– 32
"What stops Iran from stalling past Day 14?"	"The 14-day timeline has a 7-day Political Will Preservation extension for verified admin delays — but only once. Beyond that, step-back triggers apply. The Joint Disposition Fund creates financial incentive to move quickly. And the Performance-Based Graduation clock starts ticking only when compliance is verified. And if Phase 2 negotiations deadlock, Pathway A continues automatically — no breach, no collapse."	7, 9, 17
"What if the Rubio-Baghaei statements contradict each other?"	"They are pre-cleared emphasis choices, not contradictions. Both statements are grounded in Article 1.1 — custody and title are the same clause viewed from different angles. Narrative Sovereignty is by design. And Day 7 is now a conditional review process, not an automated trigger — military commanders on both sides retain discretion."	13– 14
"What about the sunset clause?"	"There is no sunset clause. The Rolling Horizon Architecture uses conditional auto-renewal based on verified compliance. The agreement continues as long as both parties comply. Either party can withdraw with notice — 90 days for Phase I. And funds already released cannot be clawed back."	30– 32
"What if Congress/Majles rejects Phase II?"	"Phase I activates by executive action — no ratification needed. Phase II items require legislative action, but Phase I extends automatically if there's delay. The JIG assesses whether delay is substantive or obstructive. Neither party can use legislative delay to kill Phase I."	27– 28
"What if a senior official leaks attribution findings?"	"A 72-hour media blackout is mandatory during attribution deliberations. Junior leaks: Tier 1 demerit. Senior official leaks (minister+): referred to JIG for Tier 2 step-back — 5% benefit reduction for 30 days per deliberate leak incident. Repeat offenses escalate. Deliberate leaks face real consequences."	23– 24
"Can a compliance dispute trigger airstrikes?"	"Absolutely not. Article 18 explicitly states that step-back, Review Pause, or even full suspension shall not be construed as authorization for military action. Any party contemplating military measures must exhaust all dispute resolution, provide 14 days' notice, and secure UNSC authorization unless responding to an ongoing armed attack under Article 51."	32– 33

"What happens to our money if we withdraw?"	"Funds already released from escrow prior to a Formal Non-Renewal Notice are not subject to return, clawback, or rescission under any circumstances . The withdrawing party retains full title and control. Only future tranches not yet released are affected. This is absolute and non-waivable."	31
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v4.0 Update Verification Checklist

Status	Item
[X]	Title and running headers updated to "The Final Steps Accord v4.0 Phase I Stabilization Framework Negotiators Brief"
[X]	14-day HEU custody timeline with Pathway A (in-Iran) default injected into Section 1.2
[X]	Political Will Preservation Clause (7-day extension) added to Nuclear section
[X]	IAEA Personnel Clarification (existing inspectors only; no foreign military) added
[X]	Joint Disposition Fund (\$500M) integrated into disposition pathway discussion
[X]	JHTA advisory status, 12-month pilot, and GCC Consultative Observer added to Hormuz section
[X]	Conditional Day 7 review-based process replaces automated 60-second trigger in Rollout Protocol
[X]	Airspace Stand-Down integrated into conditional review framework
[X]	Lebanon threshold revised: 10 casualties (not 25); JIG majority (not UNSC unanimity)
[X]	Performance-Based Graduation replaces automatic sanctions expansion in Section 2
[X]	Compliance Clock Reset rules (30-day reset for minor Tier 2) added
[X]	Congressional/Majles Opt-Out (Appendix D) added to Sanctions section
[X]	Proportional Penalties (Article 13.3) reflected in Collapse Protection table
[X]	Media Blackout Protocol (Article 13.5) with senior official escalation added
[X]	Rolling Horizon Architecture (Article 17) replaces sunset in Durability section
[X]	No Military Escalation Clause (Article 18) added to Collapse Protection
[X]	No Clawback provision added to Withdrawal Protocol
[X]	All 6 gap fixes (G1–G6) integrated into operative text
[X]	Dual-Narrative tables updated with all v4.0 provisions
[X]	Final Hour Checklist expanded with 13 Q&A entries covering all v4.0 changes
[]	Floor teams briefed on conditional Day 7 review mechanics
[]	Swiss Dashboard technical protocol tested and verified for review-based mode
[]	Both capitals confirm pre-cleared statement alignment for v4.0 text
[]	Joint Disposition Fund escrow sub-account established
[]	JHTA 12-month pilot charter drafted and circulated

[] Phase II negotiation mandate calendar blocked starting Day 90

*"This document represents the culmination of forty drafts, two wars, and decades of enmity.
It is not perfect. It is not permanent. It is possible.
And possibility, in this moment, is everything."*

The Final Steps Accord Phase I v4.0 | Late May 2026 | Authorized Negotiators Only